THE AGE

MELBOURNE LIVING

edited by PETER WEINIGER

Coca-Cola Cuisine

By Claude Forell



WITH characteristic patriotism and enthusiasm, Americans are throwing off the culinary cringe and rallying to a gastronomic declaration of independence.

It would be an exaggeration to say that the surge of interest in American regional cooking has become a popular mass movement in the United States.

And it may be premature to hail the arrival of a distinctive American cuisine, or more precisely, combination of cuisines.

But the trends are unmistakable, so much so that 'Time' magazine recently heralded the kitchen revolution in a cover story with the imperative title of 'Eat American!'

From vogue-conscious Manhattan to trend-setting San Francisco Bay, the yuppies are flocking to restaurants with chauvinistic names and nostalgic menus.

And way down yonder in New Orleans, tourists are queueing in the streets outside relatively humble eateries that have won national recognition for their Cajun-Creole specialties.

A new breed of restaurateurs and chefs are spurning French, Italian and other European menus in favor of dishes that sound, look and taste American, often reviving old recipes and presenting them in a lighter, modern form.

According to food writer Ron Rosenbaum, trend-sensitive New Yorkers "have revolted against the dictates of foreign cultures, and overthrown the minimalist aesthetics that had them famished on fashionable French *nouvelle cuisine* in the late '70s and starving on sushi in the anorectic early '80s.

"Instead, they're piling their plates high with American regional cooking, American home cooking and the newly evolving 'American cuisine'.

"American not only in the origin of its ingredients, but American in style, its openness, its melting-pot inclusiveness, its ability to combine down-home simplicity with sophisticated post-sixties sensuality."

Piling plates high is not just a turn of phrase, as I found on a five-week tour of the United States from east to west, north to south.

In one New York restaurant I was confronted at lunch with an individual "chef's salad" that could have fed four. In another, single dishes of pasta came in bowls big enough to mix a cake in, and the coffee cups looked like soup bowls with handles.

The associate editor of 'Food and Wine' magazine, Stanley Dry, told me that three trends had become evident in the US in the past year or two:—

- A boom in eating out, whether in fast food outlets or serious restaurants, with a growing preference for the less formal, more casual setting.
- Paradoxically, perhaps, a mounting interest in gourmet homecooking, judging by the rising sales of specialist magazines and cookbooks, as well as popularity of newspaper sections and television programs on food.
- A surge of interest among restaurants and their patrons in American regional cooking and its distinctive qualities, with holiday makers seeking out specialist restaurants in other states.

As if to confirm what he said, I found myself sitting next to an airline flight attendant at breakfast in a hotel reading an article on American cooking in a glossy gourmet magazine.

Obviously many well-paid single people and two-income couples with busy lifestyles eat out several times a week but enjoy cooking now and then as a hobby or for a private dinner party. And the chances are these days that they will cook something American.

'The Washington Post' food editor and restaurant critic, Phyllis Richman, told me that most of the new restaurants in and around the national capital had adopted an American theme or cuisine.

She directed me to a foremost example of the new genre, **Windows**, in a new office block overlooking the Potomac, where I feasted on Alaskan razor clams, followed by soft-shelled Maryland crabs, sauteed with garlic, tomato and butter, from Chesapeake Bay.

Also in Washington, I stumbled across a twee little place rejoicing in the name of **Bootsie, Winky and Miss Maud** which, as part of the nostalgia kick, offers a $5 lunch special of peanut and jelly sandwiches, half a dozen tollhouse cookies and all the milk you can drink.

In Philadelphia, I lunched at **Frog** with owner Steve Poses, who is regarded as one of the leaders of that city's "restaurant renaissance" over the past 10 years.

Poses is a typical self-made American go-getter who started as "a busboy and glass polisher", taught himself to cook and now owns five restaurants and food shops. And like many of the new restaurateur-chefs, he welcomes diverse influences and is not limited in his imagination by preconceived ideas.

At Frog, his chef is Iranian and the menu has French, Thai, American and Middle Eastern derivatives in the great American melting-pot tradition, offering such specialities as grilled goat cheese wrapped in a fresh basil crepe with grape coulis, roast breast of chicken stuffed with couscous, peaches and coconut with a curried lime and honey glaze, and "blackened" fillet of red snapper with wilted greens.

Poses is not alone in regarding the Cajun and Creole cuisines of Louisiana as the only genuinely indigenous American cuisines, with the evolving northern and southern Californian styles — blending Indian and Spanish influences — as the nearest contenders.

"Otherwise, the modern American cuisine is really a cuisine of the marketplace," he said. "We now have a global market. I can get endive from Belgium, mussels from New Zealand and melons from Mexico as readily and freshly as I can buy local produce, much of which now is specially grown, raised or fished in response to the enthusiasm for regional ingredients."

Steve Poses also referred to a new phenomenon of "grazing", a term I was to hear again and again. Many Americans no longer just go to one restaurant for a setpiece meal: they will call in at one place for drink, another for an appetiser and a third for a main course (or entree, as they say over there).

It is part of the new informality, and the wish to see and be seen in fashionable locales.

One of the popular new grazing fields in New York is **America**, opposite a fire station near Union Square. It is a huge barn of a place, noisy and resonant, with blue and red neon ceiling streamers pointing to a double-sided bar at the back that has become a crowded rendezvous for close encounters of the seductive kind.

The enormous menu offers such evocative dishes as Cajun popcorn (deep-fried crawfish tails with Creole sauce), dry-cured Virginia ham scrapple, New Mexican black bean cakes, Long Island duck stew (with winter root vegetables, wild mushrooms and California cabernet on wild rice and pine nut pilaff), Tuscaloosca BBQ pig pull plater and fresh Tulopo cutfish fillet fried in corn meal with hush puppies.

The duck stew was a very tasty indeed, but I did not catch up with catfish (without the hush puppies, which I feared might be too pedestrian) until I reached Little Rock, Arkansas. There I found it to be rather mushy with a faint suggestion of Mississippi mud.

Three other current in-places in New York are Larry Forgione's **An American Place**, the sleek, stylish Californian transplant **Jams**, and perhaps the most elegant and exciting of them all, **Arcadia**.



Paul Prudhomme: King of Creole.

An American Place — the name recalls a pioneering art gallery of the '30s and '40s — is small, casual and expensive, the $US52 fixed price menu offering little more than three courses with coffee and cookies.

In frugality and decorative presentation, my grilled New York State foie gras (deliciously sweet, tender and slightly pink) and broiled Maine lobster with corn salsa (which was a bit strong for the delicate lobster) were the nearest dishes to *nouvelle cuisine* that I encountered in the States.

If there is one town in the US where cooking and eating have long been taken seriously, regardless of fads and fashions, it is New Orleans, where the food is spicy and the women (at least, on Bourbon Street) are sassy.

For trendy Easterners, eating out can be more of a social than a gastronomic occasion, but down south in Louisiana they care more about the food on the plate than the surroundings or the status of their fellow diners.

As local broadcaster Bill Yeager put it, New Orleans has great food rather than great restaurants. Eating places tend to be casual, although some pride themselves on their history, such as Arnaud's (which, according to critic Jack Duarte, serves some of the best food in the country) and Antoine's (founded in 1840, and where oysters Rockefeller were created).

New Orleans is the home of Cajun and Creole cooking. The distinction between the two has become blurred, both being Louisiana born, of French roots.

The Cajuns originated in southern France, emigrated to Nova Scotia in the early 17th Century and founded a colony known as Arcadia. Driven out by the British in the mid-18th Century, many of them settled along the lush waterways of Louisiana.

There they found bountiful seafood and game, raised chicken and pork, and grew fruits and vegetables. These became the basis for a hearty rural home-cooking, flavored with such wild ingredients long used by the Indians, such as bay leaves from the laurel tree, filé powder from the sassafras tree, and a variety of peppers.

Creole cooking evolved in New Orleans, adapting French, Spanish, Italian, American, Indian and African influences to whatever foods were available. In constrast to the blandness of so much American restaurant food, Cajun and Creole dishes have taste.

As the creative flair of Paul Prudhomme has demonstrated, there is more to Cajun-Creole cooking than gumbo and jambalaya, and national publicity has brought hordes of devotees to his no-frills, cafe-style eating house, **K-Paul's**, in the French quarter of New Orleans.

Crowded out by tourists content to queue in the street for a table, many locals now go instead to the **Olde N'Awlins Cookery** nearby, where a former apprentice of Prudhomme's cooks in his style.

It is a casual, chaotic kind of place, open (unlike K-Paul's) seven days a week, where streams of people clutter the bar waiting to be seated at bare wooden tables in one of three dining areas, to feast on such spicy delicacies as seafood stuffed miriliton (a pear-shaped vegetable) with black peppercorn sauce, grilled redfin with sauteed crab fingers or barbecued (shell-yourself) shrimps Cookery style.

Owing to bad management or bad luck, I did not eat particularly well in Los Angeles or San Francisco (where the seafood restaurants of Fishermen's Wharf offer better views than food), but I did enjoy a splendid lunch at **Mustards** among the vineyards of the Napa Valley.

Here, chef Cindy Pawlcyn serves mesquite-grilled or wood-burning oven-roasted meats, fish and poultry with superb home-made condiments and locally grown fruits and vegetables.

Everything from warm goat cheese almond-coated with sun-dried tomatoes and chives to Sonoma rabbit with salsa and black beans, from cornmeal pancake with homemade sour cream and caviar to smoked rib eye steak with horseradish and parsley in virgin olive oil, is honest-to-goodness Californian fare at its best.

There are still many fashion-conscious Americans who go out to see and be seen rather than eat, and who would rather spend an evening in a chic place with mediocre food than in a humble restaurant with superb food.

But the new fascination with American produce, dishes and chefs is something to be welcomed if it proves to be more than a flash-in-the-pan fad or tiresome culinary chauvinism.

There is surely a lesson here for Australia. We, too, have an abundance of fine ingredients and a mutiplicity of talented cooks. With greater self-confidence and public recognition, we may similarly develop restaurants that will not be embarassed to call themselves Australian.

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How to survive TV torpor



YOU REALISE we are already in the non-rating period. You realise you will be in a state of torpor with your TV until deep into February.

Thank you very much, you have just appointed me as your commissar to make viewing bearable during the quarter of quietus. As your dictator I will insist that programs be labelled in the correct manner.

In France they have an *appellation controlle* which insists on the purity and origin of wine. In the United States there is the Pure Foods Act and every ingredient has to be listed on the packet.

So I would like to know how often every television repeat has been repeated. For example, 'Casablanca' is likely to be coming up for the 125th time and 'Citizen Kane' for the 184th. Admittedly they are still better than the normal fare, but we should know these things.

Just as cigarette manufacturers have to label their products as being dangerous to your health, from now on every soap, every drama will have to reveal its contents. For example: "This episode of 'Miami Vice' contains one case of incest, four shootings, six severe beatings, a rape and two examples of destruction of automobiles."

You will have noticed that there must be a law that a compere never says: "We will now have a commercial." He says: "We will take a break." That means you will have four commercials. Or he will say: "Don't go away, I'll be right back." That means you will have six commercials.

Under the new dictatorship comperes will be forced to announce exactly how many commercials there will be, and their duration. This will make life easier for the person who has to make the coffee.

We intend to place a ban on those promos. You know what I mean? The station identification with enormous grids, revolving worlds, towering 21st Century skylines, shrieking theme music and a hollering voice which tells you this program is the ultimate on Earth.

All sorts of skills in modern graphics are used and apparently they cost a fortune. But every station has them, even poor little 0-28. Slowly they send you out of your mind. Let's just have a quiet station identification — I don't mind if they have a picture of Kerry Packer or even Rupert Murdoch, as long as it is quiet, with perhaps a little insert revealing the temperature, wind strength, and the state of impurity of the air.

Meanwhile, the ABC is deeper and deeper into commercials, constantly advertising its own glory. The ABC shop gets more ads than K-Mart. One can see their problem. They have so many imported British programs, all timed to carry commercials, it is a problem to fill the hour. In the old days they would go for 10 minutes showing a swan in the Botanic Gardens or a kitten playing with wool. I am sure all of us would be happy to go back to swans and kittens.

And while we are on much-repeated British programs the new dictatorship will outlaw the awful canned laughter. The 1986 Australian viewer will be able to make up his own mind whether he wants to laugh or not.

We will make some adjustments to news programs. We are tired of reporters saying their piece striding towards camera. In future they will have to stand still. Nor do we want any more of the slow motion bit. You must have noticed that when Mr Justice Murphy or Norm Gallagher were entering or leaving court. They managed to cop those gentemen for only two or three seconds on camera. So to make the thing as dramatic as possible and, of course, absorb all the copy, they put them into slow motion, making them look as if they were in the last throes of arthritis.

Then as for the sporting news the cricket is always hard to take, 15 wickets in 15 seconds, HE'S GONE! HE'S OUT! HE'S RIGHT IN FRONT! But the racing is even worse. The greatest agony is when they give you six races in succession.

Do you think we will ever produce a race caller in this country who will be capable of describing a horse race in a gentle *sotto* voice. Instead they always scream as if these creatures on horseback were fleeing from molten lava sweeping across the racetrack.

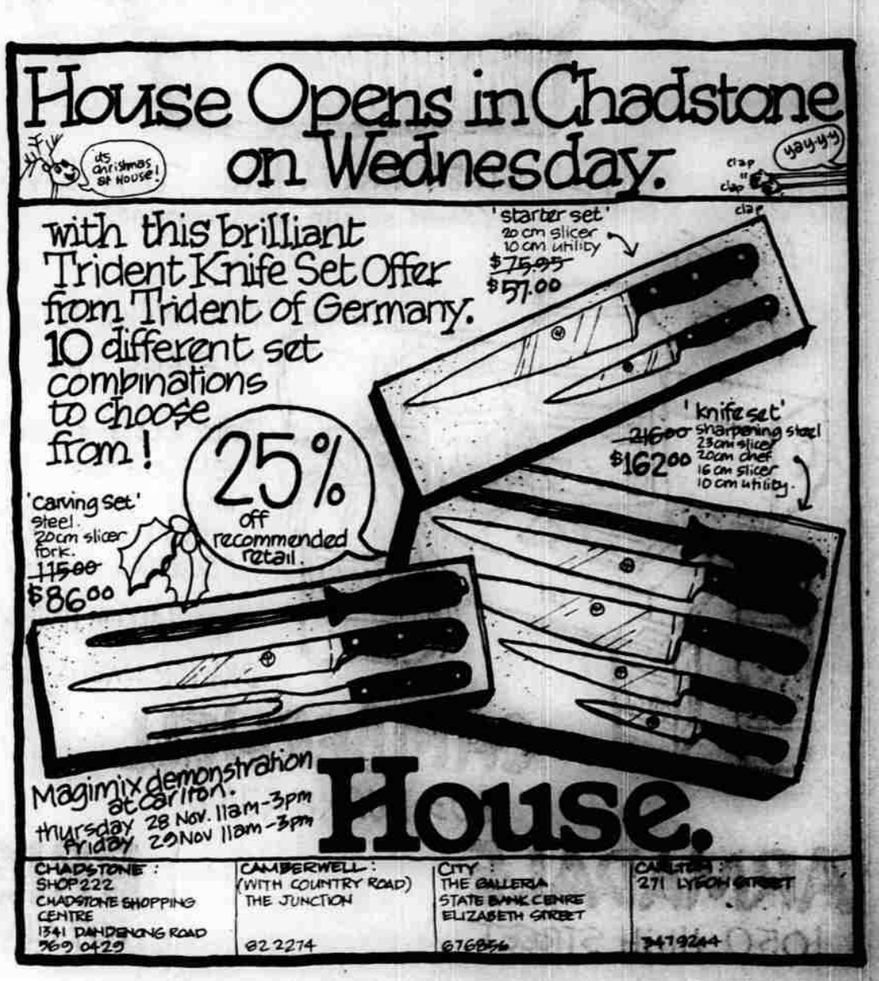
During the non-ratings period we will make it unlawful to have two good programs on television at the same time. Your chances of getting even one good program in a week are remote, but should it come along the rival channels will dredge up their finest. Several weeks back we had the 'Anzacs' series. A rival channel produced 'Gone With the Wind'.

I tell you, it was very trying. At our place we switched across during the commercials. The shock of going from World War One Ocker Paul Hogan to 19th Century southern belle Vivien Leigh every six minutes was nigh enough to cause a mental breakdown. This sort of program competition will not be tolerated under the new regime.

Oh yes, there's another thing we will stop. We will insist that Mike Willesee cease saying "Thanks for your time". They are all doing it. Even Mike Schildberger is doing it on the ABC.

Maybe we will have penalties. Those convicted of wrapping it up, taking a break or thanking us for our time will be placed in a locked booth and forced to look at 50 consecutive episodes of 'Prisoner'.

OK, if you will forgive me, that about wraps it up — and thanks for your time. — Keith Dunstan



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